

CHAPTER FOUR

My Inner Critic vs. My Inner Coach

A week later, Ms. Calloway came in and said the most important word of Book Two.

She wrote it on the board, very carefully. Two words, actually.

INNER CRITIC.

INNER COACH.

"Friends," she said, "today we are going to learn the names of the two voices inside your head."

A few of the kids who had been in Room 12 sat up. They knew this lesson. They knew the shape of this lesson. But they had not heard the words *Inner Critic* and *Inner Coach* before. In first grade, they had been called Grumpy Gus and Kind Coach. In third grade, the names had grown up a little.

That made sense to Marcus. *Grumpy Gus* was a third-grader name for a six-year-old's voice. *Inner Critic* was a grown-up name. He felt, looking at the board, that he had been promoted.

"Inside your head," said Ms. Calloway, "there is a voice. It talks to you all day long. Many of you have noticed it. Some of you talk back to it. Some of you have never realized it is there because it has been there your whole life and just sounds like thinking."

"The voice has two settings. It can be the Inner Critic. The Inner Critic is the voice that says things like *you are stupid, you always mess up, nobody likes you, you should have known better, you are not good enough*. It shows up especially when you have made a mistake, or when you are nervous, or when you are tired."

She paused.

"It can also be the Inner Coach. The Inner Coach is the voice that says things like *you can do this, everyone has a hard day, that was a mistake but it doesn't define you, you are doing your best, I am proud of you*. The Inner Coach is the voice you would use on your best friend. The Inner Coach is the voice your favorite adult uses on you."

She drew the two columns on the board.

| INNER CRITIC | INNER COACH |

|---|---|

| You are bad at this. | You are still learning. |

| You always mess up. | This time was hard. Next time will be different. |

| Nobody likes you. | Some people don't, but plenty do. |

| You are stupid. | You did one thing wrong. That doesn't mean stupid. |

| You should have known. | You couldn't have known. Now you do. |

The kids looked at the columns.

"Here is the thing. Both voices exist in every single person. You did not pick the Inner Critic. The Inner Critic is not your fault. The Inner Critic is something your brain built when you were very small, partly from things you heard from other people, partly from your brain's own way of trying to keep you safe. The Inner Critic thinks it is helping you. It thinks if it is

mean to you first, the world will not be mean to you. That is wrong. But that is what it thinks."

"Your job, this year, is not to get rid of the Inner Critic. You can't get rid of it. Nobody can. Your job is to notice it. To learn its voice. To talk back to it. To call in the Inner Coach when the Inner Critic is getting too loud."

She paused.

"This is the most important skill you will learn this year. The kids in this room who learn to talk back to the Inner Critic have an advantage that lasts the rest of their life. Adults who never learn it spend their whole lives being told mean things by the voice in their own head, and they think those things are true, because the voice is so familiar. The voice is not true. The voice is just loud."

She handed out a worksheet. Left column: WHAT MY INNER CRITIC HAS SAID TO ME THIS WEEK. Right column: WHAT MY INNER COACH WOULD SAY INSTEAD.

The kids took their pencils and started.

Priya, in the front, wrote her Inner Critic column without looking up. She wrote fast. Almost angrily.

You are not as smart as you used to be.

You forgot the answer in math yesterday and everyone saw.

You have to be perfect at this group project or your friends will think you are dragging them down.

Your handwriting is uglier than Hannah's.

Your name does not sound right when the teacher says it. You should pretend not to mind.

She stopped.

She looked at her list. She had filled the entire left column in less than three minutes. She had not written a single thing in the right column.

She sat with the worksheet.

She did not know how to talk to herself the way she would talk to her best friend. She had — actually — no idea. She had been doing the Inner Critic for so long that her brain did not know which voice the Inner Coach was supposed to sound like.

She looked across the room. Sofia was writing in both columns. Sofia had been doing this work, quietly, for two years. Sofia was, in this moment, ahead of Priya by miles.

Priya did not let this make her feel worse, although the Inner Critic offered her the chance.

She turned her paper over. On the back, she wrote: *DEAR PRIYA. If you were Hannah, and Hannah said these things to me, I would say —*

And then she paused.

What would she say to Hannah?

Hannah was Priya's best friend. Hannah had a small lisp and a habit of getting words wrong sometimes, and the kids in fourth grade up the hall sometimes laughed at her about it, and Priya was Hannah's defender. If Hannah came home from school and said *I am dumb because I can't say the word 'specifically' right*, Priya would say — Priya would say: *Hannah, you are not dumb. Your mouth is just learning a hard word. Lots of grown-ups can't say specifically. Try it as 'speh-CIF-i-cly.' Want me to practice with you?*

Priya wrote that on the back of her worksheet.

Then, very slowly, she crossed out the Inner Critic column on the front and rewrote each line in the Inner Coach voice.

You are still smart. You forgot one answer one time.

The other kids forget answers too. You just notice yours more.

Your friends like you because of who you are, not because of how perfectly you do a group project. You are not a project.

Your handwriting is yours. Hannah's is hers. There is no contest.

Your name is your name. The teacher will learn how to say it. You can tell her how. That is allowed.

Priya looked at her new column.

It did not, exactly, feel true.

The Inner Critic was still in her head, in fact, telling her that the new column was a lie, telling her that she had made it up to feel better. But Ms. Calloway had warned her about this — she had said, just five minutes ago, *the Inner Critic is loud, not true.*

Priya wrote, at the bottom of her paper, in her smallest handwriting:

The Inner Critic is loud, not true.

She underlined it three times.

She would, by November, have written it on a Post-it and stuck it on the inside of her desk lid. She would, by May, have it memorized. She would, in the years to come — in fifth grade, in sixth grade, in eighth grade, in eleventh grade, in college, in her first job — say the sentence to herself, in her head, more times than she could ever count.

She did not know any of that yet.

But she was sitting at her desk in Room 18 in October of third grade, and she had just written the most important sentence she was ever going to learn.

That was a good Friday.

Across the room, Jordan was doing something else.

Jordan had filled in the Inner Critic column with one short sentence, in big letters:

You aren't actually that funny.

He had not filled in the Inner Coach column at all.

He had closed his worksheet and was now sitting at his table doing exaggerated stretches, like an Olympic athlete preparing for a race, which was making everybody at his table giggle.

Ms. Calloway walked past Jordan's table. She paused. She did not look at Jordan's worksheet. She just paused.

"Jordan. Whenever you're ready. There's no rush."

Jordan kept stretching.

But after Ms. Calloway moved on, he sat back down. He looked at his worksheet. He picked up his pencil. In the Inner Coach column, he wrote, in much smaller handwriting than the Inner Critic line:

The fact that some people don't think you're funny doesn't mean you're not funny. It also doesn't mean funny is the most important thing about you.

He stared at it.

Then he put his pencil down and went back to stretching.

But the second sentence was there now, on the paper. And it would be there when he opened his folder next week, and the week after, and the month after. And every time he saw it, the second sentence would do its slow quiet work.

Funny is not the most important thing about you.

For Jordan, this was a piece of information he had not let himself have before. He had let himself have *being funny*. He had not let himself have anything else. The second sentence — written in his own handwriting — was a permission slip. He did not know it was a permission slip yet. But it was.

By the end of the lesson, every kid in the room had a two-column worksheet with at least one entry on each side.

Ms. Calloway said, "Friends. I want you to put these worksheets somewhere you will see them. Tape them inside your desk. Put them in the back of your binder. Take them

home and put them on your wall. Wherever. The whole point is to catch the Inner Critic the next time it shows up. And it will show up. Probably today."

Then she said one more thing.

"And I want to leave you with one sentence. Memorize this one. Hold on to it. It will help you, for the rest of your life."

She wrote it on the board.

THE INNER CRITIC IS LOUD, NOT TRUE.

The kids looked at it.

A few of them said it under their breath, just to feel what it was like to say.

Priya, who had already written it on her paper before Ms. Calloway said it, looked up and met Ms. Calloway's eyes across the room, and Ms. Calloway gave her a small private nod that meant *I saw your paper. You're ahead. Well done.*

Priya felt her chest get a little warmer.

The bell rang. Mr. Patel pulled out the social studies books. The lesson ended.

But the chart stayed on the board for the rest of the day. And the worksheet was in every kid's folder. And the sentence was in every kid's head.

The Inner Critic is loud, not true.

That sentence — that exact one — was going to come back, in different forms and with different inflections, for the rest of the year. And for the rest of the series. Marcus would say it to himself in a hospital waiting room in tenth grade. Priya would say it to her boyfriend in college. Sofia would say it to her own daughter, twenty-six years from now, when the daughter was nine and crying about a math test.

But that is a long way off.

For now, it is October, in Room 18, and the kids have a sentence. That is enough for today.